

Ivory

The hard substance from which elephant tusks are made.

Jet propulsion

The act of pushing forward by jetting out water, used by squids and octopuses.

Keratin

A tough material that makes up body parts such as hair, feathers, scales, and claws.

Krill

Tiny marine crustaceans that many animals, such as fish, whales, and seabirds, depend on for food.

Larva

The immature stage of animals that hatch from eggs and undergo metamorphosis (complete change) to become adults.

Mangrove

Trees that grow along muddy shores and river banks, often in salty water, and with many of their roots exposed.

Marine

Relating to the ocean or sea.

Metamorphosis

When an animal goes through a major change in body shape during its life cycle, such as when a caterpillar turns into a butterfly.

Microscopic

Something that is very small and can be seen only through a microscope.

Migration

The regular movement of animals from one place to another, often to find food or breed.

Mimicry

When an animal has evolved to look or act like another animal, in order to attract prey, or avoid getting eaten.

Mollusk

One of a group of invertebrates that includes snails, clams, and octopuses.

Monotreme

A group of mammals that lay eggs.

Molt

The way an animal sheds part of its outer skin, coat, or exoskeleton. In crustaceans, the regular shedding of the hard outer skeleton (exoskeleton) to allow the animal to grow.

Nectar

A sugar solution produced by flowers to attract pollinating animals such as bees and butterflies.

Nocturnal

When an animal is active at night.

Nutrition

The process of eating and processing food to absorb substances necessary for life.

Omnivorous

Refers to an animal that eats plants and meat.

Oxbow lake

A U-shaped lake formed from a river bend cut off from a river that over time has changed its course.

Pampas

Wide-stretching, grass-covered plains in temperate parts of South America.

Parasite

An organism that feeds on another, called the host, weakening it, and sometimes eventually killing it.

Pesticide

Chemicals used to kill insects and other pests that eat or damage crops.

Pigment

A substance that gives something color.

Plankton

Small organisms that drift in water.

Poaching

Illegal hunting and killing of wild animals.

Pollination

When insects and other animals carry pollen from one flower to another so that fertilization takes place and new plants can grow.

Prairie

Large, flat grasslands, with very few trees, in North America.

Prehensile

Able to coil around an object and grip it, like the tail of a monkey or chameleon.

Primate

One of a group of animals that includes lemurs, monkeys, apes, and humans.

Proboscis

A long snout, or similar organ.

Protein

A type of complex chemical found in all living things.

Range

Referring to the territory, or area, within which an animal lives.

River basin

The land in which water gathers from one or more rivers.

Roost

To settle for the night, or a place where birds, bats, and butterflies do this.

Savanna

Open grasslands in tropical regions, with only a few trees.

Scavenger

An animal that feeds on the remains of dead animals or other organic waste from living organisms.

Spawning

Releasing eggs and sperm into water so that fertilization can take place.

Species

A group of similar organisms that can interbreed and produce fertile offspring.

Subcontinent

A large landmass that is part of a bigger continent.

Subspecies

A variant of a species, usually only found in one particular area.

Subtropical

An area or climate that is nearly tropical, located at the northern or southern edge of the tropics.

Taiga

The vast coniferous forests covering the northern parts of Eurasia and North America.

Talons

The large, hooked claws of a bird of prey.

Temperate

The mild, variable climate found in areas between the tropics and the cold polar regions.

Thermals

Currents of rising warm air.

Tropical

Referring to the climate or habitats in the region around the equator, known as the tropics.

Tundra

A treeless habitat in the cold, northernmost parts of North America, Europe, and Asia, in which the ground is frozen for much of the year.